AI-Enabled Recruitment As The Branding Touchpoint: How Psychological Contract Fulfillment And Employer Brand Equity Shape Employer Attractiveness And Intention To Apply In Vietnam And Taiwan

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Abstract

This study examines how five AI-enabled recruitment (AER) attributes, including personalization, transparency, accuracy, interactivity, and intelligence, shape two core applicant states, namely AI adoption intention and psychological contract fulfillment. Drawing on the SOR framework and CBBE theory, we investigate the downstream effects of these states on employer brand equity, employer attractiveness, and intention to apply, while considering the moderating role of AI anxiety. Using a quantitative approach, 558 job-seeker surveys from Vietnam and Taiwan were analyzed using PLS-SEM. The findings reveal both convergence and contextual divergence. In both markets, AI-enabled recruitment significantly enhances AI adoption intention, which subsequently strengthens psychological contract fulfillment and employer brand equity. However, in Vietnam, these effects operate mainly through indirect, brand-mediated pathways, whereas in Taiwan they translate more directly into employer attractiveness and application intentions. Moderation analysis reveals a context-specific effect of AI anxiety: while AI anxiety does not significantly moderate the relationship between AER and AI adoption intention in Taiwan, a significant negative moderation effect is observed in Vietnam. This cross-cultural study advances recruitment and employer branding theory by integrating the SOR framework with employer branding perspectives to explain how AER shapes candidates' psychological states and subsequent brand-related and behavioral outcomes, while offering practical insights into designing human-centered and brand-consistent AER systems across Asian labor markets.

Keywords: AI enabled recruitment; Psychological contract fulfillment; Employer brand equity; Employer Attractiveness; Intention to apply; Vietnam; Taiwan

1. Introduction

Artificial Intelligence (AI) in recruitment involves the use of intelligent systems to automate repetitive hiring tasks, thereby enhancing process efficiency and responsiveness (van Esch *et al.*, 2020; Horodyski, 2023). Once considered a luxury, AI has become a strategic necessity, improving recruiter productivity while offering candidates a more streamlined and user-friendly experience (Pillai and Sivathanu, 2020; Hunkenschroer and Luetge, 2022). Moreover, AI adoption signals organizational innovativeness and strengthens employer attractiveness, contributing to a more engaging and modern recruitment process (Köchling *et al*., 2022; Huang and Rust, 2021; Sharma *et al.*, 2022).

Although the integration of AI into HRM has accelerated rapidly, research has largely emphasized technical efficiency, algorithmic accuracy, and organizational productivity (Sandeep et al., 2025), rather than applicants' psychological and social experiences (Horodyski, 2023). AER is typically framed as a functional decision-support tool, overlooking how core AI capabilities, such as personalization, transparency, accuracy, interactivity, and intelligence jointly shape applicants' perceptions of and willingness to accept AER processes. As a result, the mechanisms through which AER operates as a multidimensional experiential stimulus remain a largely unexplored "black box". Moreover, although Customer-Based Brand Equity (CBBE) theory has been extensively applied in consumer research (Bandyopadhyay et al., 2023; Milman et al., 2024; Buil et al., 2025), its application in recruitment contexts remains limited and theoretically underdeveloped. Existing studies rarely position job applicants as strategic stakeholders who co-create EBE through technology-mediated interactions (Buil et al., 2020; Georgiou and Lievens, 2022). Consequently, little is known about how AER experiences function as salient employer brand signals that transform technical system attributes into EBE, organizational attractiveness, and ITA. Empirical findings regarding applicant psychological reactions to AER are also inconsistent. While some studies suggest that AER undermines PCF due to reduced human warmth (Braganza et al., 2020; Moin et al., 2024), emerging evidence indicates that AAI may instead signal procedural AER and modernity, thereby strengthening PCF (van Esch et al., 2020). Similarly, although AI anxiety is traditionally viewed as a central barrier to technology acceptance (Acikgoz et al., 2020), recent research in competitive labor markets suggests that anxiety may no longer exert a significant moderating effect, challenging

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common assumptions in technology adoption literature . Another underexplored gap lies in the strong Western bias of AI in HRM research, which offers limited insight into Asian and other emerging labor market contexts (Horodyski, 2023). Taken together, these gaps call for a research agenda that (1) integrates the S-O-R and CBBE frameworks to clarify how AER attributes activate sequential cognitive, affective, and behavioral responses; (2) challenges prevailing assumptions about technology anxiety by testing its relevance in highly competitive career environments; and (3) provides cross-cultural empirical evidence-such as comparisons between Vietnam and Taiwan-to uncover the boundary conditions of digital employer branding.

The primary objective of this study is to explore the impact of AER on EBE and candidates' ITA within the context of Vietnam and Taiwan. Utilizing the SOR framework, the research aims to explain the underlying psychological mechanisms that occur during the recruitment process. Specifically, the model investigates how AER acts as a Stimulus that triggers candidates' internal reactions-namely candidate adoption, AI anxiety, and PCF (Organism). These internal states, in turn, influence their final behavioral responses toward the employer brand. By examining these relationships, the study seeks to understand how technological interactions shape the modern candidate experience beyond simple efficiency metrics.

Theoretically, this study extends the S-O-R model to the candidate–employer context and advances Brand Equity Theory by framing AI-enabled recruitment as a key employer brand signal rather than a purely technical tool. By incorporating AI adoption intention and psychological contract fulfillment, it clarifies how AI experiences indirectly shape employer brand equity. Practically, the findings emphasize treating AI as a candidate experience touchpoint, highlighting the need to balance efficiency with human elements and to prioritize usability and explainability alongside algorithmic accuracy to protect employer brand equity.

This study provides a systematic examination of AI adoption in recruitment. The Introduction outlines the research background, identifies key gaps, and presents the research questions. The Literature Review integrates the SOR framework and Consumer-Based Brand Equity theory to develop the conceptual model. The Methodology describes the research design, data collection in Vietnam and Taiwan, and analytical procedures. The Results report the effects of AI-enabled recruitment attributes on candidates' psychological states, brand perceptions, and application intentions, including the moderating role of AI anxiety. The Discussion situates the findings within existing literature and highlights theoretical and practical implications. Finally, the Conclusion summarizes key contributions, outlines limitations, and suggests avenues for future research.

Table 1. Previous studies and contribution of this research into the current domain

No.	Authors	Antecedent	Outcomes	Mediator/ Moderator	Theory	Country	Key findings
1	Tursunbayeva et al., 2025	AI combined with professional and personal digital data in recruitment	Intention to apply	Organizational attractiveness	Organizational; Attractiveness (OA) theory	Italy, Spain	AI in recruitment is generally viewed positively; Using AI together with personal and professional data significantly reduces organizational attractiveness and candidates' intention to apply, especially among engineering candidates
2	Wenhao Luo *et al.,* (2025)	AI-enabled interviews	Job application intention	Organizational attractiveness	Signaling theory; FAI-enabled Recruitmentness heuristic theory	China	AI interviews reduce application intention via lower justice and attractiveness, less negative in high-tech industries
3	Kulal *et al.,* (2025)	AI-driven recruitment practices	Employee engagement	AI algorithmic; Privacy consent; Legal compliance; AI transparency	SOR	India	AI improves efficiency and standardizes hiring but raises concerns over bias, opacity, and fAI-enabled Recruitmentness
4	Sandeep *et al.,* (2025)	HR competencies; Financial support; IT infrastructure; Open Innovation	AI adoption in recruitment	Managerial capabilities; Innovation capability	Resource-Based View (RBV); Dynamic Capability Framework (DCF)	India	HR competencies and open innovation positively influence dynamic managerial capabilities, which drive AI adoption in recruitment; Financial support and IT infrastructure support this process

5	Chang *et al.,* (2024)	Technology stressors	AI adoption intention	Mediators: Positive affect; AI anxiety Moderator: Technical self-efficacy	Affective Events Theory (AET); Challenge-Hindrance Stressor Framework (CHSF)	China	Emphasizes dual nature of technostress in promoting/hindering AI adoption,
6	Moin *et al.,* (2024)	Psychological contract fulfillment (PCF)	Organizational commitment	Mediator: Trust Moderator: AI acceptance	Social Exchange Theory	China	PCF influences workers' trust and organizational commitment; AI acceptance attenuates the direct and indirect positive effects of PC fulfillment on trust and organizational commitment
7	Younis *et al.*, (2024)	Perception of AI (FAI-enabled Recruitmentnes, Anxiety, Communication Accuracy, Credibility, Competency)	Employer Attractiveness		Signaling theory	Egypt	AIUI positively impacts organizational attractiveness directly for job applicants; FAI-enabled Recruitmentness and anxiety mediate PAIUI's effect on attractiveness
8	Patrick Horodyski (2023)	Perceived usefulness; Perceived ease of use AI in recruitment	Using AI system	Attitude towards AI; Behavioral intention to use	TAM	12 European nations, USA, Canada, Australia	AI-enabled recruitment is viewed positively, mainly for its efficiency, but remains concerned about accuracy and lack of human judgment.
9	Ho and Chow (2023)	AI marketing efforts (interaction, information, accessibility, customization)	Brand preference; Intention	Brand experience	SOR	Hong Kong	AI marketing efforts positively influence brand experience (except interaction, which has no significant impact); Brand experience positively affects brand preference and repurchase intention; Brand experience mediates AI marketing efforts and brand preference
10	Rožman *et al.,* (2023)	Organizational culture; AI-supported leadership; AI-supported appropriate training of employees	Employee engagement	Team's effective performance		Slovenia	AI-integrated organizational culture positively influences AI-supported leadership but not directly training; AI-supported leadership (especially for employees) impacts training and team performance
11	Köchling *et al.,* (2022)	AI-supported in recruitment stages	Organizational attractiveness	Opportunity to perform; Emotional creepiness	Affective response model	Germany	AI in later stages reduces attractiveness via lower opportunity to perform and higher creepiness
12	This Study	AI - enable recruitment (Personalization, Transparency, Accuracy, Interactivity, Intelligence)	Intention to apply; Employer Attractiveness	Mediator: AI adoption intention; Psychological contract fulfillment; Employer brand equity Moderator: AI anxiety	SOR; CEBE	Viet Nam, Taiwan	AI-enabled recruitment positively influences AI adoption intention and indirectly enhances psychological contract fulfillment, employer brand equity, employer attractiveness, and intention to apply. AI anxiety moderates this relationship only in Taiwan, while no moderating effect is found in Vietnam or the full sample.

2. Theory

2.1 Stimulus-Organism-Response (SOR) theory

SOR theory, originally proposed by Mehrabian and Russell (1974), is a widely adopted model that explains the assessment processes underlying human behavior by extending the simpler Stimulus-Response (SR) theory. This model focuses on the impact of external environmental stimuli (S) on an individual's psychology, specifically inducing changes in internal emotional and cognitive processes within the organism (O), which in turn lead to responses (R) in the form of observable actions or behaviors (Eroglu *et al.,* 2003). Prior research has extensively applied the SOR framework across diverse domains, including human-technology interaction (Eroglu *et al.,* 2001), green marketing (Nguyen *et al.,* 2024), metaverse (Abumalloh, 2024),... Within these contexts, stimuli are typically conceptualized as technological, environmental, or strategic features that trigger individuals' internal psychological mechanisms, which in turn shape behavioral outcomes. For example, Riva *et al.,* (2024) identified brand positioning as an external stimulus that influences the consumer's internal cognitive state, reflected by green brand associations, which in turn drives trust in the green brand as the behavioral response. Similarly, in the corporate recruitment context, Kulal *et al., (*2025) used SOR to explain how individuals (HR professionals, applicants, and organizations) respond cognitively and behaviorally to the use of AI in recruitment. Although AI is increasingly used in recruitment, existing studies rarely explain how AI features influence applicants' psychological states and subsequent outcomes in an integrated manner. Therefore, this study applies the SOR framework to examine how AER attributes (S) shape applicants' psychological reactions (O) and, in turn, affect recruitment-related outcomes (R).

2.2. Consumer-Based Brand Equity (CBBE) theory

CBBE theory is defined as a set of consumers' perceptions, attitudes, knowledge, and behaviors that lead to increased utility and enable a brand to achieve higher sales or profits than it would in the absence of that brand name (Keller's, 1993; Aaker, 1991). Recent studies conceptualize CBBE as a dynamic and sequential process in which brand value is built through brand awareness, understanding, and relationship development (Chatzipanagiotou *et al.*, 2016). CBBE theory has been widely applied across domains such as services, technology, strategic management,human resource management (Huo and Raffaele Filieri, 2025; Wu *et al.,* 2024) and employer branding (Buil *et al.,* 2025; Bhawna Bhawna *et al.,* 2025). However, existing CBBE research predominantly conceptualizes brand equity as a static construct, offering limited insight into the process through which brand value is formed via actual recruitment experiences, particularly those involving AER systems (Chatzipanagiotou *et al.,* 2016). Second, CBBE in management research is still largely dominated by a consumer-centric perspective, resulting in a lack of studies that consider job applicants or employees as strategic stakeholders in the co-creation of brand value. In the employer branding domain, especially within AER, the role of recruitment experiences in shaping employer brand knowledge has not been sufficiently theorized (Tasci, 2020). Prior studies have primarily focused on outcomes such as EA or ITA, without clearly elucidating the mediating mechanisms through which technology-enabled recruitment experiences contribute to EBE as an intangible brand asset (Georgiou and Lievens, 2022). Accordingly, this study adopts CBBE as the central theoretical foundation to examine AER from an applicant experience perspective. Specifically, applicants' adoption and PCF function as mechanisms through which positive brand knowledge accumulates, thereby shaping EBE and translating AI attributes into EA and ITA.

2.3 AI-enabled Recruitment (AER)

AER constitutes a construct that captures the integrated capabilities of AI technologies within the recruitment process, representing both functional and experiential aspects that collectively shape candidate perceptions and organizational adoption outcomes (Kulal *et al.,* 2025; Yu *et al.,* 2023; Olan *et al.,* 2023), is composed of five dimensions including: Personalization, Transparency, Accuracy, Interactivity, and Intelligence, each representing a distinct facet of AER, yet together forming a cohesive system capable of influencing adoption intention (Yu *et al.,* 2023). Personalization (PER) reflects the system's ability to adapt interactions, content, and feedback to individual candidate profiles and contextual preferences (Albert, 2019; Kulal *et al.,* 2025). By operationalizing candidate-centered capabilities, PER connects the functional features of AER to cognitive and affective responses, providing a mechanism through which AER can positively influence adoption intention (Albert, 2019; Clavel *et al.,* 2024). Transparency (TRA) captures the clarity, explainability, and openness of AI decision-making processes, ensuring that candidates understand evaluation criteria and procedural logic (Pan *et al.,* 2021; Hosain *et al.,* 2025; Yu *et al.,* 2023). Transparent AI reduces uncertainty and skepticism and mitigates anxiety, thereby fostering trust and reinforcing positive perceptions of AER (Köchling *et al.,* 2022). Accuracy (ACC) refers to the reliability, consistency, and correctness of AI assessments, ensuring evaluations are bias-free and dependable (Kulal *et al.,* 2025; Horodyski, 2023). Interactivity (ITR) embodies the dynamic engagement and responsiveness of AI systems, including real-time feedback and human-like communication (Clavel *et al.,* 2024; Köchling *et al.,* 2022; Younis *et al.,* 2024). Effective ITR increases perceived ease of use, reduces discomfort or distrust, and promotes positive affective responses. Intelligence (ITL) reflects the adaptive, predictive, and problem-solving capabilities of AI, enabling systems to anticipate candidate needs, optimize decisions, and provide actionable insights (Chang *et al.,* 2024; Suseno *et al.,* 2022; Horodyski, 2023; Pan *et al.,* 2021). Perceived ITL increases usefulness and operational efficiency, while acting as a positive challenge that stimulates engagement and readiness to adopt, thereby linking technological sophistication to behavioral outcomes (Chang *et al.,* 2024; Suseno *et al.,* 2022).

3. Hypothesis development

3.1 AI-enabled Recruitment (AER)

The integration of these five first-order dimensions establishes AER as a synergistic second-order construct. PER and ITR enhance candidate engagement and affective responses by operationalizing individualized and interactive experiences, thereby providing a direct pathway from system functionality to adoption behavior (Clavel *et al.,* 2024; Younis *et al.,* 2024). TRA and ACC build trust and perceived legitimacy by reducing uncertainty and validating AI-driven decisions; notably, ACC is indispensable as it reinforces the credibility of other dimensions, such as PER and TRA, ensuring consistent and reliable outcomes (Kot *et al.,* 2021; Horodyski, 2023). ITL further strengthens perceived usefulness and adoption readiness by signaling advanced problem-solving and decision-support capabilities. Empirical evidence demonstrates that systems exhibiting high levels of these capabilities significantly increase AAI, both through cognitive appraisal and affective mechanisms (Kulal *et al.,* 2025; Chang *et al.,* 2024; Jerez-Jerez, 2025; Yu *et al.,* 2023). Responding to calls for greater empirical insight into candidate experiences with AER and ethically ambiguous AI contexts (Horodyski, 2023; Tursunbayeva *et al.,* 2025), this study examines the holistic effects of AI capabilities on adoption behavior. Building on the second-order conceptualization of AER and prior evidence on the role of key AI features in fostering acceptance (Pan *et al.,* 2022; Köchling *et al.,* 2022), it is proposed that:

H1: AI-enabled Recruitment has a positive effect on AI Adoption Intention

3.2. AI adoption intention (AAI)

AAI represents a critical construct in contemporary technology acceptance research, particularly in the context of emerging digital innovations such as AI (Cheng *et al.,* 2023; Chang *et al.,* 2024). It reflects individuals' willingness to accept and utilize AI-driven systems and is shaped by a complex interplay of organizational, technological, environmental, and individual factors (Venkatesh *et el.,* 2003; Davis, 1989). Prior studies have offered mixed perspectives on the role of AAI in shaping PCF. While some scholars argue that AAI may weaken the positive relationship between PCF and work-related outcomes (Braganza *et al.,* 2020; Moin *et al.,* 2024), others highlight the importance of organizational support and managerial commitment-both closely associated with AI implementation-in strengthening employees' perceptions of fulfilled psychological obligations (Sharma *et al.,* 2022; Nguyen *et al.*, 2025). However, prior studies have primarily treated AAI as either a moderator or an outcome, leaving its direct effect on PCF underexplored. To address this gap, this study proposes that AAI has a direct and positive impact on PCF. Accordingly, it is proposed that:

H2: AI adoption intention has a positive effect on psychological contract fulfillment.

The adoption of AI in recruitment is increasingly perceived as a strategic signal that enhances EBE. Prior studies indicate that applicants respond positively to AER processes, which increase organizational attractiveness, trust, and employer reputation (van Esch *et al.,* 2020; Tursunbayeva *et al.,* 2025; Horodyski, 2023). By signaling innovation and a developmental orientation, AI also strengthens Employer Brand Image (EBI) through faster, more accurate, and more transparent recruitment experiences (Marinakou *et al.,* 2024). Moreover, AI-enabled PER and problem-solving capabilities enhance brand impressions and stimulate positive eWOM, thereby reinforcing employer positioning in competitive labor markets (Yuan *et al.,* 2022; Pandey, 2023). Applicants' acceptance of AI further contributes to Employer Brand Familiarity (EBF), as AI-based recruitment interactions increase brand exposure and recognition (Ling *et al.,* 2024; Köchling *et al.,* 2024). When candidates perceive AI as useful and easy to use, these positive evaluations simultaneously strengthen employer reputation, image, and familiarity (Roppelt *et al.,* 2025). In addition, AER platforms, chatbots, and recommendation systems provide personalized, trustworthy, and seamless experiences that foster favorable employer brand perceptions (Rani *et al.,* 2023; Noranee and Othman, 2023). Empirical evidence consistently confirms a positive relationship between AI adoption and EBE, suggesting that AI not only improves recruitment efficiency but also reinforces EBE as an intangible strategic brand asset (Younis *et al.,* 2024). Accordingly, it is proposed that:

H3: AI Adoption Intention has a positive effect on Employer Brand Equity

3.3. Psychological contract fulfillment

PCF was initially introduced by Levinson et al., (1962) and later defined as individuals' beliefs about reciprocal obligations in the employment relationship (Rousseau, 1989, 1995). Importantly, such perceived obligations may form prior to employment and be shaped through recruitment experiences and employer branding signals (Sandeepanie *et al.,* 2022). EBE represents the value an employer brand creates through its influence on employee attitudes and behaviors (Tavassoli *et al.*, 2014). When employer brand promises are fulfilled, employees are more likely to exhibit loyalty, advocacy, and positive word-of-mouth, thereby strengthening EBE (Deepa and Baral, 2021). Prior research also links PCF to favorable employer branding outcomes, including job satisfaction and retention (Tanwar and Prasad, 2016). Extending consumer-based brand equity theory to recruitment contexts (Keller, 1993), Cable and Turban (2001) conceptualize EBE in terms of employer familiarity, reputation, and image. While existing studies have examined the direct association between PCF and EBE (Deepa and Baral, 2021) and the role of EBE dimensions in recruitment branding (Banerjee *et al.,* 2020; Theurer *et al.,* 2018), their relationship remains underexplored in AI-enabled recruitment contexts. Accordingly, this study proposes:

H4: Psychological contract fulfillment is positively associated with Employer Brand Equity.

PCF has been widely recognized as a key determinant of employee attitudes and behaviors in post-hire contexts, influencing job satisfaction, commitment, and retention (Kraak *et al.,* 2024). Prior research consistently shows that PCF shapes employees' cognitive and behavioral responses toward organizational change, while psychological contract issues become particularly salient following contract breaches after organizational entry (Robinson and Rousseau, 1994; Zhao *et al.,* 2007). Accordingly, the dominant literature positions PCF as a post-hire construct with effects unfolding after individuals formally join an organization. However, psychological contract perceptions may begin forming prior to employment, based on signals conveyed during recruitment interactions. This raises the question of whether perceived PCF in the pre-engagement phase influences candidates' ITA, particularly in AER contexts where algorithmic processes may shape expectations of fairness, TRA, and reciprocity. While prior studies on AER have focused on intrinsic reactions such as perceived organizational attractiveness, novelty, or resistance toward AI systems (Beynon *et al.,* 2012), PCF has not been empirically examined as a direct antecedent of application intention. Addressing this gap, this study proposes that candidates' perceptions of PCF formed during AER may influence their willingness to apply. Accordingly, we hypothesize:

H5: Psychological contract fulfillment is associated with the applicants' intention to apply

Prior research demonstrates a significant positive association between PCF and EBE in organizational contexts (Deepa and Baral, 2021). Complementing this view, Baratelli and Colleoni, 2022) argue that employer image and EA are shaped not only by material attributes but also by non-material elements such as perceived psychological fulfillment, which enable organizations to differentiate themselves in competitive labor markets. Similarly, Tkalac Verčič *et al.* 2021) highlight the role of PCF and internal communication satisfaction in strengthening employer branding, including in AI-supported hiring contexts. During recruitment, applicants form perceptions of EA based on both explicit information (e.g., job descriptions) and implicit signals embedded in recruitment experiences (Lee *et al.,* 2011). When these signals are perceived as credible and consistent, they contribute to a favorable employer image and enhance organizational appeal (Moroko and Uncles, 2008). However, Köchling *et al.* 2022) contend that affective reactions during selection, rather than PCF per se, primarily shape EA and job acceptance intentions at the application stage, as PCF typically occurs post-hire. Building on this debate, the present study examines whether perceptions of PCF formed during AER processes are associated with EA, extending prior research beyond conventional hiring contexts. Accordingly, we propose:

H6: Psychological contract fulfillment is associated with employer attractiveness

3.4 Employer Brand Equity (EBE)

Brand equity is widely conceptualized as an intangible asset built through effective marketing and HR practices (Ambler and Barrow, 1996). Extending this notion, EBE refers to the value an employer brand generates through its influence on employees' and candidates' attitudes and behaviors (Tavassoli *et al.,* 2014). From the applicant's perspective, EA represents the perceived benefits associated with working for a particular organization (Berthon *et al.,* 2005). Prior research identifies employer reputation, a core dimension of EBE, as a critical determinant of talent attraction (Belt and Paolillo, 1982; Cable and Turban, 2003). Organizations with favorable reputations are consistently perceived as more attractive to job seekers, particularly due to the symbolic attributes embedded in employer brands (Lievens and Highhouse, 2003). Empirical evidence further shows that early recruitment practices shape employer familiarity, image, and reputation, with employer image and reputation directly predicting EA (Kashive and Khanna, 2017). More recently, Kashiv*e et al.* (2021) demonstrate that media-rich and immersive recruitment environments can further enhance EA by strengthening employer brand knowledge. Building on these insights, this study extends prior findings to the context of AER in Vietnam and Taiwan and proposes the following hypotheses.

H7: Employer Brand Equity is associated with employer attractiveness

Prior research consistently demonstrates that EBI is positively associated with applicants' ITA (Rynes, 1991; Collins and Stevens, 2002). Empirical evidence further indicates that EA, organizational reputation, and social media engagement significantly shape candidates' application intentions (Hausknecht *et al.,* 2004; Ha and Luan, 2018). These findings suggest that favorable employer brand signals enhance organizational image and motivate job seekers to pursue employment opportunities. However, existing studies have primarily examined the isolated effects of employer image and reputation, which represent two central components of EBE, while the role of employer familiarity in shaping application intentions has received limited attention. In addition, recent findings indicate that the influence of organizational reputation on ITA may be weak or context dependent (Soeling *et al.,* 2022). This observation aligns with earlier arguments suggesting that the effect of employer branding varies according to job seekers' characteristics, such as prior work experience (Wilden *et al.,* 2010). To address these gaps, the present study examines the direct association between EBE and applicants' ITA by jointly considering employer image, reputation, and familiarity within the context of AER. Accordingly, we propose:

H8: Employer Brand Equity is associated with applicants' intention to apply.

3.5 Employer attractiveness (EA)

EA refers to the benefits that potential employees perceive when considering employment with a particular organization (Berthon *et al.,* 2005). In contemporary organizational contexts, it is widely regarded as an important intangible asset that positions organizations as desirable employers aligned with the preferences of talented individuals. EA is inherently multidimensional, encompassing economic, development, application, social, and interest values evaluated by prospective applicants. Empirical research consistently demonstrates a positive association between EA and ITA. Prior studies report significant effects among younger labor segments, including Generation Z, as well as student samples (Chhabra and Sharma, 2014; Soeling *et al.,* 2022). From a generational perspective, Santiago (2018) further shows that perceived organizational attractiveness fully mediates the relationship between job attributes and ITA among Millennials. More recently, Tursunbayeva *et al.,* 2025) provide evidence that organizational attractiveness significantly influences application likelihood in AER contexts. Despite these insights, existing research has largely focused on single generational groups, and empirical evidence across broader populations in AER settings remains limited. Accordingly, this study proposes:

H9: Employer attractiveness is positively associated with intention to apply.

3.5 AI anxiety (ANX)

AI anxiety (ANX) refers to feelings of discomfort or apprehension toward AI technologies, arising from concerns about job displacement, privacy, algorithmic opacity, and loss of control (Lund *et al.,* 2024; Younis *et al.,* 2024; Suseno *et al.,* 2021). In AI-enabled recruitment, reduced human interaction may intensify these concerns, undermining trust and increasing anxiety (Köchling *et al.,* 2022; Younis *et al.,* 2024). Prior studies show that ANX negatively mediates AI adoption intentions and related behaviors, yet its role in candidate-facing recruitment contexts remains underexplored (van Esch *et al.* 2020; Horodyski, 2023; Tursunbayeva *et al.,* 2025). Accordingly, this study proposes:

H10: AI Anxiety mediates the relationship between AI-enabled Recruitment and candidates' AI Adoption Intention

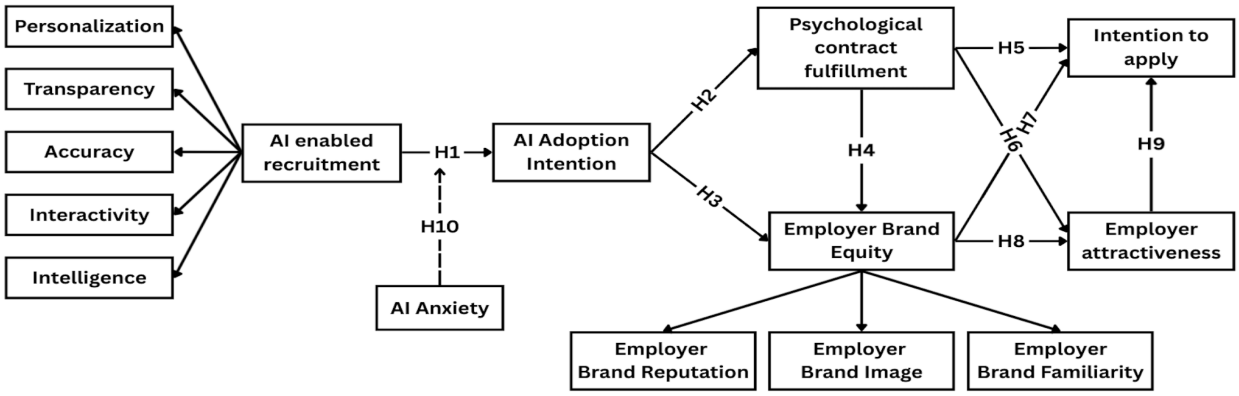


Figure 1: Research Model (Authors' own work)

4. Methods

4.1 Data Collection

To ensure validity and readability of the question AI-enabled Recruitment initially, a pretest was conducted with 30 participants, leading to revisions that enhanced the clarity of the measurement. All measurement scales were translated into Vietnamese and Traditional Chinese following the translation and back-translation procedure. Some items were rephrased slightly to make the questions more easily understood by respondents. Participants were recruited through an online survey employing non-probability sampling. The survey was conducted in Vietnam and Taiwan with 630 respondents, who were recruited through an online survey using non-probability sampling, specifically employing a snowball sampling method. To identify targeted respondents, two screening questions were used: (1) "Have you ever participated in a recruitment process?" and (2) "Which AI-based tools or applications are you familiar with or have you encountered in recruitment processes? (*e.g., automated CV screening systems, chatbots for candidate assistance, AI-conducted interviews, AI-powered candidate data analytics,...*). The questionnaire required approximately 15-20 minutes to complete, and all responses and personal information were kept confidential. We used SMARTPLS 4 software (Ringle *et al.,* 2014) to test the measurement model and structural model of the proposed model, due to its PLS-SEM specialization, it easily create and evaluate SEM models, and suitable for complex models with multiple mediation and moderation variables with higher level of statistical power and small samples size, making it appropriate choice for this study (Benitez *et al.,* 2020; HAI-enabled Recruitment *et al.,* 2019). Following data screening, 558 valid responses were retained, including 226 from Vietnam and 332 from Taiwan. In **Table 2** summarizes the demographic characteristics of the respondents.

TABLE 2 | Demographic descriptives

Dimension	Vietnam (n =226)		Taiwan (n=332)		Full (n=558)	
	F	%	F	%	F	%
Age						
Below 25 years old	48	21.2	70	21.1	118	21.1
25 - 35 years old	110	48.7	168	50.6	278	49.8
36 - 45 years old	40	17.7	52	15.7	92	16.5
46 - 55 years old	20	8.8	28	8.4	48	8.6
Above 56 years old	8	3.5	14	4.2	22	3.9
Gender						
Male	118	52.2	162	48.8	280	50.2
Female	108	47.8	170	51.2	278	49.8
Education level						
Below Bachelor's degree	54	23.9	62	18.7	116	20.8
Bachelor's degree	118	52.2	176	53	294	52.7
Master's degree	42	18.6	70	21.1	112	20.1
Doctoral degree	12	5.3	24	7.2	36	6.5
Monthly income						
Below US$390	72	31.9	48	14.5	120	21.5
US$390 - US$780	84	37.2	96	28.9	180	32.3
US$781 - US$1,500	46	20.4	88	26.5	134	24.0
US$1,501 - US$2,100	18	8.0	56	16.9	74	13.3
US$2,101 - US$2,800	6	2.7	44	13.3	50	9.0
Above US$2,800	72	31.9	48	14.5	120	21.5

4.2 Measurement

We developed a theoretical model by reviewing and utilizing scales from several relevant research on the following variables: AER, ANX, AAI, PCF, EBE, EA and ITA. All items were paraphrased effectively to make them fit in the context of our study. After this adaptation, we converted them to Vietnamese and Traditional Chinese with careful consideration of the research background. A 7-point Likert scale, ranging from "Strongly Disagree" (1) to "Strongly Agree" (7), was used to rate all items. AER is the first higher-order construct, has five dimensions: PER, TRA, ACC, ITR, ITL. PER was measured with five items from Pillai *et al.,* (2023). The scale of TRA was adapted from Höddinghaus *et al.,* (2021) with three items. Four items of ACC were derived from Yuan *et al.,* (2022). ITR was measured with six items from Pillai *et at.,* (2023). The final dimension is ITL was adapted from Pillai *et al.,* (2023) with five items. The ANX variable which mediated the relationship between AER and AAI was adapted from Chang *et al.,* (2024) with five items. AAI was measured with five items from Ivanov *et al.,* (2023). PCF was derived from Tkalac Verčič *et al.,* (2021) with four items. EBE, the second higher-order construct, included three dimensions: Employer Brand Reputation (EBR), Employer Brand Image (EBI) and Employer Brand Familiarity (EBF). EBR was measured with four items from Tkalac Verčič and Sinčić Ćorić, 2018. EBI was derived from Özcan and Elçi, (2020) with seven items. And the final dimension, EBF was measured with three items from Soeling *et al.*, (2022). EA was derived from Buitek *et al.,* (2023) with six items. ITA (the dependent variable of the model) was measured with six items from Highhouse *et al.,* 2003.

4.3 Data Analysis

Our research employed the partial least squares structural equation modeling (PLS-SEM) technique using SmartPLS 4 software (Ringle *et al.,* 2024) to analyze the theoretical model and evaluate the proposed hypotheses. PLS-SEM was selected because it offers strong methodological advantages for models that include higher-order constructs composed of both reflective and formative indicators and moderating variables in complex research frameworks (Becker *et al.,* 2023). In addition, PLS-SEM is a preferred method because it is non-parametric, meaning it does not require the data to be normally distributed. This makes it an appropriate choice for analyzing datasets with non-normal characteristics or smaller to medium sample sizes. SmartPLS 4 further enhances this approach by offering an intuitive interface, efficient algorithm performance, and advanced capabilities for evaluating both measurement and structural models. This technique is uniquely capable of managing multiple independent variables simultaneously and analyzing path models based on composites (Hair *et al.,* 2021). Numerous scholars have published studies in recent years in the field of AI-enabled systems and digital technology adoption that have used PLS-SEM (Sandeep *et al.,* 2025; Ho and Chow, 2023), confirming that this method is suitable for the research context of our study.

5. Results

5.1 Common Method Bias (CMB)

This research used a single-source question AER, which may create covariance among variables and increase the complexity of data analysis (MacKenzie and Podsakoff, 2012). To address this concern, both procedural and statistical remedies were applied to check for common method bias (CMB). Procedural remedies were introduced before data collection (ex ante), while statistical remedies were conducted after data

collection (ex post). On the procedural side, the question AER was carefully designed to minimize bias. Respondents were given clear instructions, informed that there were no correct or incorrect responses, and were guaranteed anonymity. The survey was kept concise, avoided repetitive items, and included both positively and negatively worded questions to reduce response bias. In addition, psychological separation was applied to disguise the link between independent and dependent variables. The question AER was translated into Vietnamese and Traditional Chinese, with technical terms supplemented by explanations to enhance clarity and ensure respondent comfort (MacKenzie and Podsakoff, 2012). On the statistical side, two methods were applied: the Variance Inflation Factor (VIF) for the inner model (Hair *et al.,* 2019) and Harman's single-factor test (Babin *et al.,* 2016). The VIF values ranged from 1.431 to 2.927, all of which were below the recommended threshold of 3.333. The maximum variance explained by a single factor was 43.45%, lower than the 50% threshold. These results indicate that the dataset is not significantly affected by CMB.

5.2 Measurement model

The results in **Table 3** confirm satisfactory reliability and convergent validity for both the Vietnamese and Taiwanese samples. Most outer loadings exceed 0.70, with a few items between 0.50 and 0.70 remaining acceptable (Hair *et al.,* 2019). All constructs demonstrate adequate internal consistency, with Cronbach's Alpha and Composite Reliability values above 0.70 (Henseler and Sarstedt, 2013; Hair *et al.,* 2021). Convergent validity is supported as most AVE values exceed 0.50; although the second-order constructs AER and EBE report slightly lower AVE, their CR values exceed acceptable thresholds, justifying their retention (Sarstedt *et al.,* 2019). Discriminant validity is established based on HTMT values below 0.90 (**Table 4**) (Rasoolimanesh *et al.*, 2016) and the Fornell and Larcker (1981) criterion (**Table 5**). Overall, the measurement model demonstrates adequate reliability and validity.

TABLE 3 | The reliability and convergent validity

Variables	**FL**		**CA**		**CR**		**AVE**	
	VN	**TW**	**VN**	**TW**	**VN**	**TW**	**VN**	**TW**
AER *(Second order)*			**0.851**	**0.876**	**0.893**	**0.910**	**0.627**	**0.671**
PER			**0.770**	**0.843**	**0.846**	**0.889**	**0.529**	**0.616**
PER1	0.813	0.743						
PER2	0.751	0.761						
PER3	0.707	0.879						
PER4	0.806	0.793						
PER5	0.518	0.741						
TRA			**0.745**	**0.876**	**0.847**	**0.924**	**0.649**	**0.802**
TRA1	0.744	0.885						
TRA2	0.810	0.929						
TRA3	0.859	0.871						
ACC			**0.782**	**0.821**	**0.859**	**0.882**	**0.603**	**0.653**
ACC1	0.787	0.801						
ACC2	0.768	0.838						
ACC3	0.749	0.849						
ACC4	0.801	0.739						
ITR			**0.867**	**0.846**	**0.900**	**0.886**	**0.601**	**0.565**
ITR1	0.799	0.697						
ITR2	0.812	0.746						
ITR3	0.783	0.761						
ITR4	0.722	0.797						
ITR5	0.786	0.776						
ITR6	0.747	0.728						
ITL			**0.806**	**0.876**	**0.866**	**0.910**	**0.564**	**0.671**
ITL1	0.732	0.753						
ITL2	0.822	0.853						
ITL3	0.722	0.860						

ITL4	0.800	0.831						
ITL5	0.670	0.793						
ANX			**0.845**	**0.844**	**0.888**	**0.885**	**0.613**	**0.607**
AX1	0.755	0.787						
AX2	0.801	0.811						
AX3	0.828	0.753						
AX4	0.830	0.746						
AX5	0.694	0.796						
AAI			**0.838**	**0.823**	**0.903**	**0.894**	**0.756**	**0.739**
AAI1	0.849	0.853						
AAI2	0.878	0.883						
AAI3	0.880	0.842						
PCF			**0.735**	**0.811**	**0.834**	**0.877**	**0.558**	**0.642**
PCF1	0.776	0.665						
PCF2	0.730	0.849						
PCF3	0.748	0.847						
PCF4	0.732	0.83						
EBE ***(Second order)***			**0.820**	**0.859**	**0.914**	**0.859**	**0.780**	**0.780**
EBR			**0.843**	**0.843**	**0.894**	**0.895**	**0.679**	**0.681**
EBR1	0.839	0.814						
EBR2	0.832	0.880						
EBR3	0.840	0.847						
EBR4	0.785	0.756						
EBI			**0.857**	**0.887**	**0.891**	**0.911**	**0.541**	**0.595**
EBI1	0.609	0.767						
EBI2	0.711	0.787						
EBI3	0.754	0.742						
EBI4	0.729	0.789						
EBI5	0.783	0.779						
EBI6	0.759	0.773						
EBI7	0.785	0.761						
EBF			**0.795**	**0.865**	**0.880**	**0.917**	**0.709**	**0.788**
EBF1	0.837	0.895						
EBF2	0.842	0.915						
EBF3	0.847	0.851						
EA			**0.837**	**0.862**	**0.880**	**0.897**	**0.551**	**0.591**
EA1	0.744	0.765						
EA2	0.705	0.739						
EA3	0.749	0.781						
EA4	0.730	0.793						
EA5	0.780	0.798						
EA6	0.745	0.736						
ITA			**0.850**	**0.843**	**0.894**	**0.910**	**0.628**	**0.669**
ITA1	0.825	0.838						
ITA2	0.827	0.879						
ITA3	0.829	0.847						
ITA4	0.813	0.750						

ITA5	0.655	0.768

Abbreviations: ***VN:*** *Vietnam;* ***TW:*** *Taiwan;* ***FL****: Factor loading;* ***CA****:Cronbach's alpha;* ***CR****: Composite Reliability ;* ***AVE****: Average Variance Extracted;* ***AER:*** *AI enabled recruitment;* ***PER:*** *Personalization;* ***TRA:*** *Transparency;* ***ACC:*** *Accuracy;* ***ITR:*** *Interactivity;* ***ITL:*** *Intelligence;* ***ANX:*** *AI Anxiety;* ***AAI:*** *AI adoption intention;* ***PCF:*** *Psychological contract fulfillment;* ***EBE:*** *Employer Brand Equity;* ***EBR:*** *Employer Brand Reputation;* ***EBI:*** *Employer Brand Image;* ***EBF:*** *Employer Brand Familiarity;* ***EA:*** *Employer attractiveness;* ***ITA:*** *Intention to Apply*

TABLE 4 | Heterotrait-Monotrait Ratio (HTMT)

Vietnam Construct	AAI	AER	ANX	EA	EBE	ITA	PCF
AAI							
AER	0.851						
ANX	0.553	0.708					
AE	0.758	0.842	0.667				
EBE	0.715	0.867	0.649	0.819			
ITA	0.648	0.874	0.609	0.740	0.778		
PCF	0.675	0.872	0.701	0.790	0.790	0.694	
Taiwan Construct	**AAI**	**AER**	**ANX**	**EA**	**EBE**	**ITA**	**PCF**
AAI							
AER	0.850						
ANX	0.622	0.797					
AE	0.789	0.851	0.779				
EBE	0.735	0.868	0.743	0.819			
ITA	0.626	0.861	0.666	0.710	0.788		
PCF	0.678	0.885	0.786	0.752	0.783	0.669	

Abbreviations: ***AAI:*** *AI adoption intention;* ***AER:*** *AI enabled recruitment;* ***ANX:*** *AI Anxiety;* ***EA:*** *Employer attractiveness;* ***EBE:*** *Employer Brand Equity;* ***ITA:*** *Intention to Apply;* ***PCF:*** *Psychological contract fulfillment*

TABLE 5 | Fornell-Larcker criterion

Vietnam Construct	AAI	AER	ANX	EA	EBE	ITA	PCF
AAI	0.869						
AER	0.674	0.792					
ANX	0.358	0.473	0.783				
AE	0.527	0.663	0.385	0.743			
EBE	0.477	0.669	0.405	0.655	0.857		
ITA	0.485	0.704	0.419	0.627	0.558	0.793	
PCF	0.470	0.658	0.437	0.653	0.601	0.540	0.747
Taiwan Construct	**AAI**	**AER**	**ANX**	**EA**	**EBE**	**ITA**	**PCF**
AAI	0.859						
AER	0.727	0.819					
ANX	0.563	0.704	0.779				
AE	0.665	0.742	0.676	0.769			
EBE	0.619	0.750	0.642	0.705	0.883		
ITA	0.532	0.743	0.581	0.621	0.683	0.818	

PCF	0.553	0.751	0.657	0.637	0.658	0.569	0.801

Abbreviations: ***AAI:*** *AI adoption intention;* ***AER:*** *AI enabled recruitment;* ***ANX:*** *AI Anxiety;* ***EA:*** *Employer attractiveness;* ***EBE:*** *Employer Brand Equity;* ***ITA:*** *Intention to Apply;* ***PCF:*** *Psychological contract fulfillment*

5.3 Structural model

The collinearity analysis indicated that the VIF for each independent variable stayed comfortably under the suggested limit of 5.0, most of them being the majority approximating 3 or less. These outcomes demonstrate that the model did not suffer from multicollinearity (Hairt *et al.,* 2019). After the bootstrapping process, refer to **Table 6**, the obtained R-squared values, falling within the range of 0.306 - 0.565, indicate an acceptable degree of model adequacy. A normed fit index above 0.7 and a standardized root mean square residual of 0.05 indicate that the proposed model aligns well with the collected data as presented in **Table 6.** In testing the proposed hypotheses, the relationships among variables (**see Table 7**) were examined through t-test statistics along with the p-values corresponding to each path.. Due to enhancing the reliability of results, a nonparametric bootstrapping procedure was applied, thereby permitting a finer estimation of the hypotheses (Becker *et al.*, 2022). As shown by t-test values greater than 2.3 and p-values under 0.05, all the hypotheses are confirmed (Rasoolimanesh *et al*., 2016).

For Vietnam, the results indicate that AER positively influences AAI, with a path coefficient of 0.646 (p = 0.000; H1 supported). In turn, AAI has a significant positive effect on PCF (β = 0.470, p = 0.000; H2 supported) and on EBE (β = 0.250, p = 0.000; H3 supported). PCF further positively impacts EBE (β = 0.484, p = 0.000; H4 supported), ITA for a position (β = 0.165, p = 0.036; H5 supported), and EA (β = 0.406, p = 0.000; H6 supported). EBE also exerts a significant positive effect on both ITA (β = 0.208, p = 0.013; H7 supported) and EA (β = 0.411, p = 0.000; H8 supported). Finally, EA positively influences ITA for a position (β = 0.383, p = 0.000; H9 supported) (see **Table 8**).

For Taiwan, a similar pattern emerges. AER positively affects AAI (β = 0.651, p = 0.000; H1 supported), which in turn significantly influences PCF (β = 0.553, p = 0.000; H2 supported) and EBE (β = 0.368, p = 0.000; H3 supported). PCF further has a positive impact on EBE (β = 0.454, p = 0.000; H4 supported), ITA (β = 0.142, p = 0.017; H5 supported), and EA (β = 0.305, p = 0.000; H6 supported). EBE significantly drives both ITA (β = 0.428, p = 0.000; H7 supported) and EA (β = 0.505, p = 0.000; H8 supported). Finally, EA positively affects ITA for a position (β = 0.228, p = 0.000; H9 supported) (see **Table 8**).

TABLE 6 | R-Square

Variables	R-Square	R-Square adjusted
AAI	0.543	0.541
EA	0.565	0.563
EBE	0.519	0.517
ITA	0.523	0.521
PCF	0.306	0.305

Abbreviations: ***AAI****: AI Adoption Intention;* ***PCF****: Psychological contract fulfillment;* ***EBE****: Employer Brand Equity;* ***EA****: Employer Attractiveness;* ***ITA****: Intention To Apply*

TABLE 7 | Model Fit Summary

	Saturated model	Estimated model
SRMR	0.075	0.161
d_ULS	2.755	12.817
d_G	26.471	28.118
Chi-square	6985.091	7291.326
NFI	0.445	0.421

TABLE 8 | Path coefficients-mean, p values

Full Hypothesis	Vietnam			Taiwan					
	β	p	Decision	β	p	Decision	β	p	Decision
AER→ AAI = H1	0.713	0.000	**Accepted**	0.646	0.000	**Accepted**	0.651	0.000	**Accepted**
AAI → PCF = H2	0.553	0.000	**Accepted**	0.470	0.000	**Accepted**	0.553	0.000	**Accepted**
AAI → EBE = H3	0.333	0.000	**Accepted**	0.250	0.000	**Accepted**	0.368	0.000	**Accepted**
PCF → EBE = H4	0.460	0.000	**Accepted**	0.484	0.000	**Accepted**	0.454	0.000	**Accepted**
PCF → ITA = H5	0.151	0.001	**Accepted**	0.165	0.036	**Accepted**	0.142	0.017	**Accepted**
PCF → EA = H6	0.341	0.000	**Accepted**	0.406	0.000	**Accepted**	0.305	0.000	**Accepted**
EBE → ITA = H7	0.382	0.000	**Accepted**	0.208	0.013	**Accepted**	0.428	0.000	**Accepted**
EBE → EA = H8	0.483	0.000	**Accepted**	0.411	0.000	**Accepted**	0.505	0.000	**Accepted**
EA → ITA = H9	0.275	0.000	**Accepted**	0.383	0.000	**Accepted**	0.228	0.000	**Accepted**

Abbreviations: ***AAI:*** *AI adoption intention;* ***AER:*** *AI enabled recruitment;* ***ANX:*** *AI Anxiety;* ***EA:*** *Employer attractiveness;* ***EBE:*** *Employer Brand Equity;* ***ITA:*** *Intention to Apply;* ***PCF:*** *Psychological contract fulfillment*

5.4 Analyses of moderation

The model incorporates the interaction variable to examine whether ANX moderates the effect of AER on employees' AAI. For Vietnam, the hypothesized moderation effect was significant. ANX moderated the relationship between AER and AAI (β = - 0.073, p = 0.043), and therefore the moderation hypothesis was accepted. For Taiwan, the results showed a non-significant moderation effect. ANX did not moderate the relationship between AER and AAI (β = 0.017, p = 0.636), supporting the moderation hypothesis. For the full sample, no significant moderation effect was observed (β = - 0.014, p = 0.569), leading to the rejection of the moderation hypothesis. Taken together, these findings suggest that while AER directly affects AAI, ANX only moderates this effect in the Taiwanese context, but not in Vietnam or across the full sample (see **Table 9**).

TABLE 9 | Path coefficients - mean, p values of moderators

Full Hypothesis				Vietnam			Taiwan		
	β	p	Decision	β	p	Decision	β	p	Decision
AER x ANX -> AAI	- 0.014	0.569	**Rejected**	- 0.073	0.043	**Accepted**	0.017	0.636	**Rejected**

Abbreviations: *AER: AI-Enabled Recruitment; ANX: AI Anxiety; AAI: AI Adoption Intention*

6. Discussion

This study examines how five core dimensions of AER including PER, TRA, ACC, ITR, and ITL, shape candidates' AAI. It further explores how AAI influences PCF and EBE, which in turn affect EA and ITA, while accounting for the moderating role of ANX. Drawing on the S-O-R framework and CBBE theory, this study explains how AER acts as a stimulus that shapes applicants' perceptions of employer brand value and drives their adoption and application intentions.

The results support H1 in both markets, showing a significant positive effect of AER on AAI in Vietnam (β = 0.646, p = 0.000) and Taiwan (β = 0.651, p < 0.001). The stronger effect in Taiwan suggests higher technological readiness, consistent with prior cross-country studies (Albert, 2019; Yu *et al.,* 2023; Kulal *et al.*, 2025). Additionally, H2 and H3 are also supported, indicating that AAI positively influences PCF and EBE in both contexts, with stronger effects in Taiwan (PCF: Vietnam β = 0.470, Taiwan β = 0.553; EBE: Vietnam β = 0.250, Taiwan β = 0.368; p < 0.001). These findings imply that in more technologically mature environments, candidates' openness to AER more readily translates into perceptions of organizational fairness and employer brand strength, thereby reinforcing AI's role as an effective employer brand signal (van Esch *et al.,* 2020), rather than weakening the psychological bond as suggested by prior critiques (Braganza *et al.,* 2020; Moin *et al.,* 2024).

Secondly, the study examines the relationship between PCF and employer branding outcomes. The results support H4 in both Vietnam and Taiwan, showing that higher PCF significantly enhances employer brand equity (Vietnam: β = 0.484; Taiwan: β = 0.454; p < 0.001). The similar effect sizes suggest that fulfilling implicit employer obligations is a fundamental mechanism for strengthening EBE across markets, consistent with prior research (Deepa and Baral, 2021; Sandeepanie *et al.,* 2022). This consistency may reflect shared cultural values emphasizing reciprocity and long-term relational exchange in East Asian contexts. With respect to H5, PCF shows a significant but modest direct effect on intention to apply (ITA) in both Vietnam (β = 0.165) and Taiwan (β = 0.142; p < 0.001), suggesting that PCF is a meaningful but not dominant predictor of application intentions. This contrasts with prior studies reporting stronger direct effects (Heuvel *et al.*, 2017; Kraak *et al*., 2024), indicating that in these Asian contexts PCF may operate primarily through indirect pathways. Supporting H6, PCF positively predicts employer attractiveness (EA) in both countries (Vietnam: β = 0.406; Taiwan: β = 0.305; p < 0.001), with a stronger effect in Vietnam, highlighting the importance of perceived employer reliability and fairness in emerging labor markets (Baratelli and Colleoni, 2022; Köchling *et al*., 2022). Overall, the findings suggest that PCF influences ITA mainly through mediators such as EBE and EA rather than through a strong direct effect.

Regarding H7, EBE exerts a positive effect on EA in both Taiwan (β = 0.428) and Vietnam (β = 0.208). This finding is consistent with the view that EBE represents an intangible asset accumulated through effective marketing and human resource practices, and that organizational reputation plays a central role in enhancing EA (Belt and Paolillo, 1982; Cable and Turban, 2003; Lievens and Highhouse, 2003). The stronger effect observed in Taiwan suggests that applicants in this market place greater emphasis on long-term brand signals when evaluating EA (Kashive *et al.,* 2021). With respect to H8, EBE shows a significant positive relationship with ITA in both Taiwan (β = 0.505) and Vietnam (β = 0.411). This result aligns with prior research demonstrating that EBI and EBR are key drivers of applicants' job pursuit intentions (Ha and Luan, 2018). Although recent studies suggest that the effect of reputation may vary across contexts (Soeling *et al.,* 2022), the present findings confirm the continued relevance of EBE in influencing application intentions, even within AER environments.

Finally, H9 is also supported, indicating that EA positively predicts ITA in both Vietnam (β = 0.383) and Taiwan (β = 0.228). This finding reinforces the conceptualization of EA as a valuable intangible asset reflecting economic, developmental, and social benefits perceived by applicants. Consistent with prior empirical evidence, EA remains a strong predictor of application intentions across diverse applicant groups (Soeling *et al.,* 2022), and this relationship persists in the context of AER (Tursunbayeva *et al.,* 2025).

The results for H10 reveal a context-specific moderating role of AI anxiety (ANX) in the relationship between AER and AAI. For Taiwanese respondents, the interaction effect is not significant (β = 0.017, p = 0.636), indicating that ANX does not meaningfully alter adoption intentions. This suggests that in Taiwan, AI-related concerns are largely decoupled from behavioral responses, likely due to the advanced institutionalization and normalization of AI in recruitment, where participation in AER is often perceived as unavoidable rather than optional (Acikgoz *et al.,* 2020; Babaee and Shank, 2025). In contrast, ANX significantly and negatively moderates the AER-AAI relationship in Vietnam (β = -0.073, p = 0.043), indicating that higher anxiety weakens applicants' willingness to adopt AER. This finding implies that in less institutionalized AI contexts, AI-related concerns regarding trust and fairness remain salient boundary conditions, amplifying anxiety and constraining adoption intentions (Tursunbayeva *et al.,* 2025).

7. Conclusion

7.1 Theoretical Implications

This study advances theory by extending established perspectives on technology adoption and employer branding to the context of AI-enabled recruitment (AER). By integrating the SOR framework with employer branding literature, the findings demonstrate that AER functions as a socio-technical stimulus that shapes candidates' cognitive and emotional states, which in turn influence employer brand equity, employer attractiveness, and intention to apply. Specifically, the results extend the SOR model beyond traditional consumer and digital service contexts to recruitment, highlighting the relevance of internal psychological mechanisms such as AI affinity and psychological contract fulfillment. Moreover, the study contributes to employer branding theory by identifying the AI recruitment experience as an important early brand signal, suggesting that direct technological interactions play a critical role in employer brand formation in digitally transforming organizations. Finally, the findings challenge technology-centric views of AI recruitment by framing it as a social and psychological experience. The nonsignificant effects of AI anxiety further suggest that negative emotions toward AI do not necessarily translate into avoidance behavior, indicating that candidates' responses to recruitment AI are context-dependent.

7.2 Practical Implications

This study provides practical insights for key stakeholders involved in AER, including HR departments, employer branding teams, and AI solution providers. The findings highlight that AI recruitment systems influence not only operational efficiency but also candidates' psychological experiences and brand perceptions, underscoring the need for strategic and human-centered implementation. **First**, for HR departments, the results suggest that AI should be managed as a critical candidate experience touchpoint rather than solely as a screening or automation tool. While AI can support decision-making efficiency, maintaining TRA and human presence at key stages of the recruitment process is essential to mitigate perceptions of unfairness and impersonality and to foster positive psychological responses among candidates. **Second**, the findings carry important implications for employer branding. EBE is shaped not only by external communication but also by candidates' actual experiences with AER systems. Ensuring consistency between communicated brand values, such as fairness, TRA, and innovation, and the design and use of AI in recruitment is crucial for strengthening candidates' trust and perceptions of PCF. **Third**, for AI solution providers, the study emphasizes that candidate acceptance is as important as technical ACC. Designing AI systems with clear explanations, user-friendly interfaces, and transparent communication regarding AI's role in recruitment can enhance adoption and reduce anxiety, thereby indirectly supporting the employer brand of client organizations. **Overall**, these implications suggest that organizations can leverage AI recruitment effectively through incremental and feasible adjustments, such as improving communication, training HR staff, and refining system design. By aligning technological efficiency with candidates' psychological experiences, firms can maximize the benefits of AER while safeguarding EBE and application outcomes.

7.3 Limitations and future research

This study has several limitations that offer directions for future research. First, the research was conducted in only two Asian markets with similar cultural and institutional contexts, namely Taiwan and Vietnam, which limits the generalizability of the findings. Future studies should extend the model to other Asian and European countries to enable cross-cultural comparisons of AI adoption in recruitment. Second, the Taiwanese sample primarily included individuals aged 25-35, limiting the representation of Generation Z, an emerging core workforce. Future research should therefore include a more diverse age distribution, with a stronger focus on Generation Z, to better capture generational

differences in attitudes toward AER practices. Third, although ANX was theorized as a moderating variable, its moderating effect was not clearly supported by the empirical results. This suggests that the role of ANX may be more complex or context-dependent than initially anticipated. Consequently, future studies should re-examine this moderating effect using alternative measurement scales, different research designs, or larger and more diverse samples before drawing definitive conclusions. Additionally, future research could incorporate other potential moderating variables, such as trust in AI, job type, industry characteristics, level of technological literacy, and organizational size, to provide a more nuanced understanding of AI adoption in recruitment. Fourth, AI adoption in recruitment was examined at a general level without distinguishing between different AI-based tools. Future research should differentiate between candidate-facing and internal AI recruitment technologies to better understand their distinct effects on applicants' perceptions and intentions. Finally, the lack of a direct effect of PCF on candidates' ITA, particularly in Vietnam, warrants further investigation. Qualitative or mixed-method approaches are recommended to explore contextual explanations for this finding in AER settings.

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